Phishing Awareness Guide for Students

Cybersecurity Awareness Task

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Topic: Identifying and Preventing Phishing Attacks

1. Five common warning signs of phishing

Phishing is a cyberattack in which attackers pretend to be trusted people or organizations to trick victims into revealing sensitive information, clicking malicious links, or downloading harmful attachments.

The five major warning signs are:

Warning sign	Explanation
1. Unusual sender address	The sender's email address looks fake or uses a misspelled company domain.
2. Urgent requests	Messages threaten account suspension or demand immediate action.
3. Unexpected attachments	Unknown files may contain malware.
4. Suspicious links	Links may lead to fake websites designed to steal information.
5. Password requests	Legitimate services should not ask you to share your password through email or messages.

2. Three analysed example phishing messages

The following are fictional educational examples. They do not contain real credentials, private information, or active malicious links.

Example 1: Fake bank security alert

Subject: Unauthorized Transaction Detected

Phishing

From: security-alert@fakebank-example.com

Dear Customer,

We suspect an unauthorized transaction on your account. To protect your account, please click the verification link and confirm your identity immediately.

Thank you,
Bank Security Team

Warning signs:

- Unusual sender address that does not match the official bank domain.
- Creates fear about an unauthorized transaction.
- Uses urgency to pressure the recipient.
- Requests identity verification through a message link.
- Uses a generic greeting instead of the customer's name.

Analysis: The attacker pretends to be a bank to make the victim reveal personal or banking information.

Example 2: Fake account verification

Subject: Account Verification Required

Phishing

From: account-support@example-fake.com

Dear User,

During our regular account verification, we could not verify your information. Please update your account details immediately to avoid losing access to your account.

Regards,
Account Support Team

Warning signs:

- Unfamiliar sender address.
- Unexpected account verification request.
- Threatens loss of account access.
- Asks users to update personal information.
- Uses a generic greeting.

Analysis: This message tries to trick users into submitting sensitive information through a fake verification process.

Example 3: Fake refund notification

Subject: You Have a Pending Refund

Phishing

From: refund-service@example-fake.com

Dear Customer,

Our records indicate that your account has been overcharged. Contact our refund department within seven days to claim your money. Provide your account details to process the refund.

Thank you,
Refund Department

Warning signs:

- Unknown sender address.
- Unexpected refund notification.
- Creates a deadline to pressure the recipient.
- Requests account details.
- Offers a financial benefit to encourage a response.

Analysis: Attackers use the promise of receiving money to convince victims to share sensitive financial information.

Educational basis: CISA's phishing awareness examples, adapted into fictional messages without active links or real contact information.

3. What should you do after receiving a suspicious message?

1. Stop: Do not respond immediately.
2. Do not click: Avoid suspicious links and QR codes.
3. Do not download: Never open unexpected attachments.
4. Verify: Contact the organization using its official website or phone number.
5. Report: Use your email provider's Report Phishing option or inform your school's IT department.
6. Delete: Remove the suspicious message after reporting it.

If you accidentally enter your password on a suspicious website, change it immediately using the official website, enable multi-factor authentication (MFA), and notify the relevant organization.

4. One-page phishing awareness guide for students

STOP! THINK! VERIFY!

PHISHING AWARENESS FOR STUDENTS

Protect your identity. Protect your accounts. Stay cyber safe.



What is phishing?

Phishing is a cyberattack where criminals pretend to be trusted organizations or people to steal passwords, personal information, or financial details.

Recognize these 5 warning signs

1. Fake sender: Unusual or misspelled email address.

2. Urgency: Threats such as "Act immediately!"

3. Attachments: Unexpected files from unknown senders.

4. Suspicious links: Fake websites pretending to be real.

5. Password requests: Requests for passwords or verification codes.

What should you do?

- Never click suspicious links.
- Never download unknown attachments.
- Never share your password or OTP.
- Verify messages through official channels.
- Report suspicious emails to your teacher or IT department.
- Use strong, unique passwords and MFA.

THINK BEFORE YOU CLICK!

One careless click can expose your personal information. Stay alert and stay safe online.

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5. Trusted educational resources and screenshot evidence

1. FTC – How to Recognize and Avoid Phishing Scams — includes a real-world educational phishing email example.
2. UC Davis – How to Spot Phishing Messages — includes example phishing messages and explanations.
3. CISA – Phishing Awareness PDF — contains example phishing messages and safety advice.

6. Conclusion

Phishing is a common cybersecurity threat that can affect students, teachers, and organizations. Learning to identify suspicious sender addresses, urgent messages, unexpected attachments, suspicious links, and password requests helps prevent cyberattacks.